

THE EMPEROR WHO WOULD NOT KNEEL

Chapter 5 — “The Heavenly Envoy”

Format: Traditional right-to-left manga script. Read panels right-to-left, top-to-bottom.

Black-and-white. Heavy ink shadow, cinematic negative space, screentone.

Approx. 28 pages.

PAGE 1

Panels: 3

Panel 1 (wide, full-width top — atmospheric opening)

The Wastes have no morning. Only darkness thinning by degrees. Pale gray light spreads across the broken plain, revealing black stone, collapsed towers, rusted weapons half-buried in ash. In the distance, a dead city leans against the horizon like a wounded animal.

No dialogue.

Panel 2 (narrow, center)

EGRIS stands at the edge of the camp, watching the souls behind him wake.

No dialogue.

Panel 3

The dead rise quietly. No stretching, no yawning. Some stare at their hands. Others search faces, still hoping to find someone lost.

NARRATION (box): They did not wake as the living did.

PAGE 2

Panels: 4

Panel 1

A WOMAN IN RED sits beside a low fire that gives no warmth. She holds the hand of a BOY, no older than ten. He has not spoken since Egris saved him from the Hollow Men.

No dialogue.

Panel 2

Near a ruined watchtower, three SOLDIERS argue in whispers over a blade with no edge. One wears armor Egris doesn't recognize. Another, desert warrior dress. The third's clothes are strips of gray cloth hanging from his frame.

No dialogue.

Panel 3

NARRATION (box): They had been enemies once. Even here, beyond life, men carried their wars with them.

Panel 4

Close on EGRIS's face, understanding.

NARRATION (box): He understood that. He had carried his own.

PAGE 3**Panels: 3****Panel 1**

A voice behind him — BORCHU, the old soldier with the split face-wound.

BORCHU: "You have been standing there for too long."

Panel 2

EGRIS, not turning.

EGRIS: "Then you have been watching me for too long."

Panel 3

BORCHU gives a dry laugh.

SFX: heh

PAGE 4**Panels: 4****Panel 1**

BORCHU, standing straight despite his wound.

BORCHU: "You watch them as if they are already yours."

Panel 2

EGRIS: "They are not mine."

Panel 3

BORCHU: "No?"

Panel 4

EGRIS finally looks at him.

No dialogue.

PAGE 5**Panels: 3****Panel 1**

BORCHU: "They followed you. They sleep near your fire. They wait for you to speak before they move."

Panel 2

BORCHU: "If that is not ownership, what is it?"

Panel 3

EGRIS, flat.

EGRIS: "It is caution."

PAGE 6**Panels: 3****Panel 1**

BORCHU: "Caution is what prey feels when a wolf enters the valley."

Panel 2

EGRIS's eyes narrow.

No dialogue.

Panel 3

EGRIS: "Then perhaps they should stop behaving like prey."

PAGE 7**Panels: 2****Panel 1**

BORCHU nods once, as though Egris confirmed something for him.

No dialogue.

Panel 2 (wide, bottom — the moment the air CHANGES)

The fire behind them goes OUT. Not dimmed. CEASED. Every soul in the camp goes still.

SFX: ...

PAGE 8**Panels: 3** (silent page — building dread)**Panel 1**

The gray light across the Wastes withdraws, as if something swallowed it. The ruins darken.

No dialogue.

Panel 2

The ashes beneath Egris's boots begin to rise in thin spirals, turning slowly around him.

SFX (soft): fwsss

Panel 3

Everyone frozen, watching the sky.

No dialogue.

PAGE 9**Panels: 1** (FULL-PAGE SPLASH — page-turn reveal)

The sky OPENS. A line of white fire appears above the broken plain, cutting through darkness from one horizon to the other.

No sound. No dialogue. Pure visual.

PAGE 10

Panels: 3

Panel 1

The dead FALL to their knees. Some willingly. Others look confused, horrified by their own bodies folding beneath them.

No dialogue.

Panel 2

The boy cries out, clinging to the woman. The three soldiers press their faces to the ground.

SFX (soft, layered): crying, whimpers

Panel 3

BORCHU remains standing. So does EGRIS.

No dialogue.

PAGE 11

Panels: 2

Panel 1 (large, top — the descent)

The white line widens. A SHAPE descends through it — at first seeming to be a man wrapped in light. Then the armor becomes visible: bright metal without scratches, fitted like a second skin. A long cloak of white feathers moves behind him, though there is no wind. A sword burns within its sheath at his side.

No dialogue.

Panel 2 (narrow, close on the ENVOY's face)

His face is almost human. Almost. Too still. Too perfect. Eyes with no reflection of the ruined land below.

No dialogue.

PAGE 12

Panels: 3

Panel 1

The ENVOY touches the ground several paces from Egris. Where his feet meet ash, small white FLOWERS rise — fragile, impossible.

No dialogue.

Panel 2

The dead watch the flowers in silence, transfixed.

No dialogue.

Panel 3

The envoy's gaze moves over the camp, lingering on the kneeling souls. Then it comes to rest on EGRIS.

No dialogue.

PAGE 13**Panels: 3****Panel 1**

The ENVOY speaks. His voice carries like a command.

SERAPHEL: "Egris."

Panel 2

EGRIS does not move.

EGRIS: "You know me."

Panel 3

SERAPHEL: "I know what you were."

PAGE 14**Panels: 4****Panel 1**

EGRIS: "No. You know what you were told."

Panel 2

For the first time, something changes in Seraphel's face. A faint shadow of recognition.

No dialogue.

Panel 3

SERAPHEL: "I am Seraphel. General of the Seventh Host. Voice of the Throne Beyond the Gate."

Panel 4

EGRIS, dry.

EGRIS: "A long name."

PAGE 15**Panels: 4****Panel 1**

SERAPHEL: "A necessary one."

Panel 2

EGRIS: "Nothing is necessary except death."

Panel 3

A murmur passes through the camp. Souls glance at one another, waiting to see if lightning will strike.
No dialogue.

Panel 4

SERAPHEL's eyes turn briefly toward the ruins beyond the camp.
SERAPHEL: "The Wastes have made you proud."

PAGE 16**Panels: 5****Panel 1**

EGRIS: "The Wastes have made me awake."

Panel 2

SERAPHEL: "You were offered a place."

Panel 3

EGRIS: "I was offered a chain."

Panel 4

SERAPHEL: "God offered you purpose."

Panel 5

EGRIS: "God offered me obedience."

PAGE 17**Panels: 3****Panel 1**

SERAPHEL: "Order."

Panel 2

EGRIS: "Obedience wearing a better mask."

Panel 3 (wide — the flowers beneath Seraphel's feet grow taller)

SERAPHEL's expression hardens by a fraction.

No dialogue.

PAGE 18**Panels: 3****Panel 1**

SERAPHEL: "You speak of chains, yet already the dead gather behind you. Already they watch you as soldiers watch a commander."

Panel 2

SERAPHEL: "You call Heaven a prison because you fear being ruled. But what will you call the empire you intend to build?"

Panel 3

EGRIS looks back at the camp. At the frightened child. At the woman holding him. At the soldiers. At Borchu.

No dialogue.

PAGE 19**Panels: 3****Panel 1**

EGRIS: "I have not built an empire."

Panel 2

SERAPHEL steps closer.

SERAPHEL: "No. Not yet."

Panel 3

The air around him is warm now. It smells of rain, clean stone, open grass beneath blue sky.

No dialogue.

PAGE 20**Panels: 2****Panel 1**

SERAPHEL: "Heaven does not seek to destroy you. The Throne sees your strength. It sees your will. It knows what you could become here."

Panel 2

EGRIS: "Then it should be afraid."

PAGE 21**Panels: 3****Panel 1**

SERAPHEL: "It is not."

Panel 2

EGRIS: "Everything should fear what it cannot control."

Panel 3

For a moment, Seraphel says nothing.

No dialogue.

PAGE 22

Panels: 1 (FULL-PAGE SPLASH — the VISION)

Seraphel raises one hand. The darkness vanishes. The camp disappears. The Wastes disappear.

EGRIS stands on a high hill beneath a vast golden sky. Below him: a city greater than any he has ever seen. White and gold towers. Shining rivers. Perfect roads. No ruined homes, no burning fields, no starving children. Men and women move through wide streets without fear. Thousands of soldiers carry weapons lowered. No one screams. No one runs.

SERAPHEL beside him: "A world at peace."

PAGE 23

Panels: 4

Panel 1

EGRIS looks down at the city.

EGRIS: "Whose peace?"

Panel 2

SERAPHEL: "The peace of the redeemed."

Panel 3

EGRIS: "Those who obey."

Panel 4

SERAPHEL: "Those who understand."

PAGE 24

Panels: 3

Panel 1

EGRIS: "And those who do not?"

Panel 2 (wide — the dark truth of the vision)

Far beyond the city gates, a long road winds toward a wall of white stone. A line of souls walks that road, quiet and orderly, wearing the same pale garments. None look left or right. None speak. No dialogue.

Panel 3

SERAPHEL: "They are given their place."

PAGE 25

Panels: 4

Panel 1

EGRIS: "They are assigned it."

Panel 2

SERAPHEL: "They are spared confusion."

Panel 3

EGRIS: "They are spared choice."

Panel 4

The vision TREMBLES.

No dialogue.

PAGE 26**Panels: 2****Panel 1**

The golden sky breaks apart. The hill vanishes. Egris stands once more in the Wastes. The flowers are gone. The fire in the camp remains dead.

No dialogue.

Panel 2

SERAPHEL looks less like light now and more like a weapon forged to resemble a man.

No dialogue.

PAGE 27**Panels: 3****Panel 1**

SERAPHEL: "You mistake freedom for strength. You mistake defiance for wisdom."

Panel 2

SERAPHEL: "God does not demand your submission because He needs another servant. He demands it because every soul requires a place in the order of things."

Panel 3

EGRIS steps forward until only a few feet separate them.

No dialogue.

PAGE 28**Panels: 1 (FULL-PAGE SPLASH — Egris's answer)**

EGRIS speaks, quiet but cutting. The camp listens more closely because of it.

EGRIS: "I had a place once. I was born weak enough for men to believe they could break me. I watched allies turn against one another. I watched men swear loyalty in the morning and betray it before nightfall. I watched rulers call themselves chosen while their people starved beneath them. I did not survive because some higher power gave me a place. I survived because I took one."

At the bottom: Seraphel's eyes flicker.

PAGE 29

Panels: 5

Panel 1

SERAPHEL: "You took it with blood."

Panel 2

EGRIS: "Yes."

Panel 3

SERAPHEL: "With fear."

Panel 4

EGRIS: "Yes."

Panel 5

SERAPHEL: "With conquest."

PAGE 30

Panels: 2

Panel 1

EGRIS's jaw tightens.

EGRIS: "Yes."

Panel 2 (wide — the word hangs between them)

It is not a defense. Not an apology.

No dialogue.

PAGE 31

Panels: 3

Panel 1

SERAPHEL studies him as though seeing the shape of his soul for the first time.

No dialogue.

Panel 2

Then the angel reaches for the sword at his side.

No dialogue.

Panel 3

The dead RECOIL. BORCHU moves toward Egris, but Egris lifts one hand without looking back.

NARRATION (box): Stay.

PAGE 32

Panels: 2

Panel 1 (large, top — SERAPHEL draws the blade)

Its light is so bright that the shadows of every soul stretch across the ground behind them.

SFX: SHNNNG

Panel 2

SERAPHEL: "I have been commanded to bring you before the Throne."

PAGE 33

Panels: 3

Panel 1

EGRIS: "Then you should have brought an army."

Panel 2

SERAPHEL, cold.

SERAPHEL: "I did."

Panel 3 (wide, bottom — building dread)

No dialogue.

PAGE 34

Panels: 1 (FULL-PAGE SPLASH — THE HOST DESCENDS)

The sky OPENS again. Not a single line this time. HUNDREDS. They descend like falling stars. Winged figures in armor, carrying spears of light and banners with no symbols. The ground shakes as they approach.

The Hollow Men hunted like animals.

These beings come like a JUDGMENT.

SFX: BOOM BOOM BOOM

PAGE 35

Panels: 3

Panel 1

Fear spreads through the camp. The woman grabs the boy and pulls him close. Soldiers stumble backward.

No dialogue.

Panel 2

Some kneeling souls begin to pray — desperate, frightened prayers.

No dialogue.

Panel 3

EGRIS hears the prayers. Not because they are loud. Because they are desperate.

No dialogue.

PAGE 36

Panels: 2

Panel 1

SERAPHEL points his sword toward Egris.

SERAPHEL: "Kneel. Accept the mercy offered to you. Let these souls enter the light. Let order be restored."

Panel 2

EGRIS looks at the dead behind him. They are afraid. They have every reason to be.

No dialogue.

PAGE 37

Panels: 3

Panel 1

EGRIS looks upward at the descending host.

NARRATION (box): He had stood before armies before. He had known what it meant to send others toward death while remaining alive long enough to count the cost.

Panel 2

NARRATION (box): But these were not his soldiers. Not yet. He could not command their loyalty. He could not demand their courage.

Panel 3

So he turns to them.

No dialogue.

PAGE 38

Panels: 2

Panel 1 (large, top — the command)

EGRIS: "Stand."

Panel 2 (wide, bottom)

No one moves. The white light continues to fall.

No dialogue.

PAGE 39

Panels: 2

Panel 1

EGRIS raises his voice.

EGRIS: "I said stand."

Panel 2 (wide — the BOY is the first)

His legs shake as he pushes himself upright. The woman rises beside him, still holding his hand.
 Borchu stands with them. Then one soldier rises. Then another.
 No dialogue.

PAGE 40**Panels: 1** (FULL-PAGE SPLASH — THE STAND)

Slowly, unevenly, the camp STANDS. Not because they believe they can win. Not because Egris promised safety. But because they were given a CHOICE.

Wide shot: the ragged line of dead souls, standing together, facing the descending heavenly army. Egris at the front with his cracked spear. Small. Defiant. Together.

PAGE 41**Panels: 3****Panel 1**

SERAPHEL's face becomes cold.

SERAPHEL: "You would lead them into destruction."

Panel 2

EGRIS: "No. I would let them decide whether they live on their knees."

Panel 3

The angel lifts his blade.

No dialogue.

PAGE 42**Panels: 2****Panel 1**

EGRIS reaches down and pulls an old spear from the ash. The wood is cracked. The metal head is dark with age. It is not enough.

No dialogue.

Panel 2

But it is in his hand.

No dialogue.

PAGE 43**Panels: 1** (FULL-PAGE SPLASH — closing image)

Above them, Heaven's army descends. Below, Egris and the standing souls wait. For the first time since entering the Wastes, Egris does not stand alone.

NARRATION (box, lower corner): And for the first time since entering the Wastes, Egris did not stand alone.

— END OF CHAPTER 5 —

SCRIPT NOTES (for artist / letterer)

- **Reading direction:** Right-to-left. Panel 1 sits at top-right of every page.
- **This is a spectacle chapter.** The Heavenly Host must feel MASSIVE — use scale, light, and overwhelming numbers. They are not evil, but they are absolute.
- **Page 9 splash (sky opens)** — simple, clean, one line of white fire. No detail yet. Let the reveal build.
- **Page 22 splash (the vision)** — show the “perfect” city in full detail so we understand what Egris is refusing. Make it beautiful. Make it soulless.
- **Page 34 splash (the Host descends)** is the centerpiece spectacle. HUNDREDS of angels. This should feel unstoppable.
- **Page 40 splash (the stand)** is the emotional climax. The souls standing is more important than the angels descending. Frame it as a small, fragile, CHOSEN defiance.
- **Seraphel’s design:** bright armor, white feather cloak, burning sword. He is not cruel — he is CERTAIN. His face should be almost human but too perfect, too still.
- **Tone shift:** This chapter moves from philosophical debate → vision → ultimatum → defiance. Each beat should be clearly marked visually.